

Friday 8 March 2024

Meeting Communiqué

Commonwealth, state, and territory agriculture ministers met virtually on Friday 8 March 2024, for the first Agriculture Ministers' Meeting (AMM) of the year.

AMM 01/2024 was chaired by the Australian Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry, Senator the Hon Murray Watt. Minister Watt welcomed the new AMM member for Northern Territory, the Hon Mark Monaghan MLA, and thanked former Minister the Hon Paul Kirby MLA for his contribution to AMM during this time as Minister for Agribusiness and Fisheries in Northern Territory.

Ministers noted the impact of natural disasters, drought and biosecurity outbreaks on local production and discussed the ongoing support being provided to affected producers.

ABARES Outlook

Ministers were briefed by ABARES on its latest forecast for the agriculture sector for the 2024-25 year. Ministers welcomed the forecast rebound in overall production, led by increases in crop, livestock, and horticulture production.

2024 Priorities

In 2024, AMM will focus on its agreed priorities of biosecurity, climate smart agriculture, First Nations agriculture, trade, workforce, animal welfare and drought. Ministers will also use this forum to tackle any emerging nationwide challenges that arise.

Cost of Living

Ministers recognised that cost of living pressures were a constant across all jurisdictions. Ministers discussed measures put in place at the Commonwealth and jurisdictional level to help ease cost of living pressures on Australian farmers and families. Ministers noted that there are a number of reviews and inquiries occurring that are designed to lift transparency and competition in the food supply chain and encouraged people to take advantage of these and make submissions.

Climate Smart Agriculture

Minister Watt provided an update on the recent consultation process for the Agriculture, Land and Emissions discussion paper, which sought views on opportunities for the sector to contribute to the whole-of-economy net zero target. Over 230 submissions were received from a range of stakeholders, which will now be considered in the development of the Plan. Ministers discussed emerging themes from the feedback, the differential nature of jurisdictions regarding in particular market access for their export products and how the barriers to achieving a low-emissions future for agriculture could be overcome in all jurisdictions.

First Nations Agriculture

Minister Watt provided an update on the development of the National Statement on First Nations in Agriculture (National Statement). Ministers noted that a taskforce of Commonwealth, State and Territory representatives to drive the development of the National Statement has convened twice and identified shared opportunities and potential partnerships with First Nations peoples.

Ministers agreed the National Statement be provided to AMM in the first quarter of 2025 for endorsement, subject to the necessary time and opportunity to partner with First Nations peoples. Ministers approved the taskforce to explore options to support the implementation of the National Statement. They also endorsed the National Statement be driven by the principles of self-determination and that it should be an ambitious commitment that advances First Nations perspectives, experiences, and interests in the drive for greater Indigenous economic inclusion in the agriculture, fisheries, and forestry sectors.

Agriculture workforce

Ministers discussed the ongoing workforce issues that face parts of the sector across the country. Ministers noted the work underway across jurisdictions to deal with these issues and requested further discussion by AGSOC for report back at the next AMM.

Animal welfare

Ministers confirmed their commitment to jointly leading the renewal of the Australian Animal Welfare Strategy, informed by broad stakeholder engagement and a principles-based framework. To underpin development of the strategy, Ministers agreed to work towards the development of a National Statement on Animal Welfare during 2024.

Biosecurity

Red Imported Fire Ants

Ministers noted the update on the National Fire Ant Eradication Program (NFAEP) Response Plan 2023-27 and forward budget commitments.

Ministers acknowledged the commencement of new governance arrangements for the Program, with the inaugural Red Imported Fire Ants (SEQ) National Management Group meeting occurring on 22 February 2024. The arrangements aim to align with the principles of the National Environmental Biosecurity Response Agreement arrangements.

Ministers also noted the joint efforts between the NFAEP and New South Wales in response to detections of fire ants in Murwillumbah and Wardell, NSW, with surveillance and treatment measures in place.

Biosecurity Sustainable Funding

Minister Watt provided an overview on the Commonwealth's Biosecurity Sustainable Funding package as announced in the 2023-24 Budget and provided an update on the additional financial contributions being made by taxpayers, importers, travellers and producers through the proposed Biosecurity Protection Levy.

Agricultural traceability

Ministers noted the importance of implementing mandatory electronic identification (eID) for sheep and goats, from 1 January 2025, to enhance Australia's national livestock traceability. Ministers also noted the importance of transition support for producers and industry across the supply chain in supporting implementation.

Carp control virus

Ministers noted the working group convened by the DAFF Secretary and fisheries officials from Victoria, New South Wales, South Australia and Queensland to consider development of a proposal for a trial controlled release of the carp virus.

Support for the viticulture and wine sector*

Ministers acknowledged the significant challenges facing wine grape growers, particularly in the inland regions and noted the work to date of governments to build new markets and provide financial and other support to wine grape growers through the current oversupply of red wine grapes.

Ministers agreed to establish a viticulture and wine sector working group, comprising representatives of the Commonwealth, state and territory governments, Wine Australia, Australian Grape and Wine and other relevant groups as agreed by the working group, to provide recommendations to Agriculture Ministers to address the challenges facing growers.

The working group will be expected to visit regions most impacted by the oversupply, including the Riverland in SA and the Riverina in NSW, and will report back to Agriculture Ministers out of session by the end of April 2024. The working group will also propose to Agriculture Ministers actions to support improvement in the grape and wine sector and its long-term viability by July.

*Minister Jarvis declared a potential conflict of interest and did not participate in discussion on this item.

Next meeting

Ministers agreed to meet next in person on Thursday, 18 July 2024.

Ministerial attendees

- Australian Government (Chair): Senator the Hon Murray Watt, Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry and Minister for Emergency Management
- Australian Capital Territory: Rebecca Vassarotti, MLA, Minister for the Environment, Parks and Land Management; Minister for Heritage; Minister for Homelessness and Housing Services; and Minister for Sustainable Building and Construction
- New South Wales: Hon Tara Moriarty MLC, Minister for Agriculture; Minister for Regional New South Wales; and Minister for Western New South Wales
- Northern Territory: Hon Mark Monaghan MLA, Minister for Education; Minister for Mining; and Minister for Agribusiness and Fisheries
- Queensland: Hon Mark Furner MP, Minister for Agricultural Industry Development and Fisheries; and Minister for Rural Communities
- South Australia: Hon Clare Scriven MLC, Minister for Primary Industries and Regional Development; and Minister for Forest Industries
- Tasmania: Vanessa Pinto, A/g Secretary for Primary Industries and Water at Department of Natural Resources and Environment was a proxy for the Hon Jo Palmer MLC, Minister for Primary Industries and Water; Minister for Community Services and Development; Minister for Disability Services; and Minister for Women and the Prevention of Family Violence, due to the Tasmanian elections.
- Victoria: Hon Ros Spence, Minister for Agriculture; Minister for Community Sport; and Minister for Carer and Volunteers.
- Western Australia: Hon Jackie Jarvis MLC, Minister for Agriculture and Food; Forestry; Small Business

Source: <https://www.agriculture.gov.au/about/news/stay-informed/communiques/ag-ministers-forum-mar-2024>